

A Place to Rest

“Hmmm... are you feeling okay, Aya?” Kira glanced up from her notes at the young autognome, who was stumbling around drowsily. Aya walked straight into a table and plopped backwards onto the ground without a word, staring blankly ahead. Kira took that as all the confirmation she needed and picked her daughter up. She carried her across the room and sat her on a table in the corner. “Now, what seems to be the problem, young lady?”

“Aya bumped her head playing with the fishies outside and now she’s tired.” The little construct tilted her head somewhat but said nothing further.

“Hmm... did you tell Mama?” Kira asked. The robot nodded her head.

“Mama said it was nice and called Aya sweetie.”

Kira sighed and rolled her eyes. She’d have to have a discussion with her wife later. “Well, *sweetie*, is there a reason you’re calling yourself Aya?” The autognome stared quizzically at Kira, as though she didn’t understand the question. “Well, that’s okay, I guess. We’ll try to fix you right up.” Kira began to inspect Aya’s head; she reached out telekinetically and pulled a magnifying lens over, holding it in place as she examined her plating. The sound of hurried footsteps broke into her concentration as E ran up the steps, huffing, clearly out of breath. Kira took a step back and glanced at her wife.

“Well, well, if it isn’t the illusive Elyssa Asato! What could we *possibly* do for you on this fine evening?” Kira was already fairly confident she knew what was happening, but she couldn’t resist the opportunity to tease her wife.

The gnome glanced at Kira, then averted her eyes shyly. “I... I heard Aya got hurt...” she said, in between breaths. “I’m so sorry, I was just engrossed in this book I was reading and didn’t even realize! Is she okay??” E looked genuinely concerned; despite her mistake, it was clear she cared for their daughter. Kira couldn’t help but smile; sure, her wife’s tunnel vision could cause issues sometimes, but it was also part of what Kira loved about her. When E set her mind to something, nothing could stop her.

“I’m sure she’ll be fine, E. Why don’t you come take a look with me?” The gnome started to approach the table but stopped just short.

“Hold on a second, I’ll be right back!” She took off running down the stairs again. While she was gone, Kira finished her preliminary checkup. Externally, aside from a few bumps and scratches, there was really only one major injury. A small section of the outer plating on Aya’s head had been cracked open, with a pair of wires getting scraped together. The two were creating a short, draining more energy than normal and presumably also messing with the language processing area of her brain, which was right behind the wires. *More than likely, it shouldn’t be too complex to fix*, she thought. At this point, E returned, huffing even more than before. She was carrying an armful of pillows and books.

“I... got... some... stuff...” She walked slowly over to the table, catching her breath as she went. “I brought... some pillows. So Aya can lay on them. And books, too. Ones with lots of pictures, since

she can't read yet. I figure, while we're trying to fix her up, we might as well make her comfortable while she's waiting." The gnome reached out and grasped her daughter's hand. "We're gonna fix you right up, don't you worry! Mama and *Amme* can fix anything, okay?"

She turned to Kira, who began to explain what she'd found. As she did, they helped Aya situate the pillows underneath herself, while Aya began to "investigate" the book for clues to help her parents. Before long, the pair had begun working on patching up their daughter. Before they'd even finished, Aya had drifted off into sleep mode, lying comfortably on the workbench. As the duo finished fixing her up, Kira looked down at her wife.

"You know, if our daughter keeps this up, she's going to be spending a lot of time on this table, getting fixed. She's too much like you." Kira playfully jabbed at her wife's shoulder.

"Me? *Me*? Mrs. 'I'm going to travel across the entire known universe to fight dragons and clockwork abominations' thinks our daughter gets hurt because she takes after *me*? I'm much safer than you are!" As soon as she'd finished saying it, they both broke into laughter; considering how many times E'd almost blown up the house—or herself—neither one of them could take that seriously.

As their laughter faded, E reached up and took her wife's hand. "You do have a point, though. Maybe we should see about getting her a special seat here, so she'll at least be comfortable. I'd hate for her to stop exploring and learning just because of some bumps and bruises."

The sea elf nodded her head in agreement. "Maybe tomorrow, when she wakes up, we'll ask her and see what kinds of things she'd want here—let her help, too. For now, just let her sleep."